in the quarterfinal, so could three players of colour play in the semifinal, or was that not the case?

I was certainly not blind to the wider issues and I regarded the process of transformation in South African cricket not as something imposed upon the game but as something that was morally the right thing to do. As far as I was aware, everybody in the game supported Cricket South Africa in their missionary zeal to ensure all South Africans enjoyed an equal opportunity to play cricket and to reach the highest levels. Cricket's development programme had been launched by Dr Ali Bacher when he was MD of the United Cricket Board, had continued under Gerald Majola and Haroon Lorgat, and was widely and consistently praised.

However, since we all shared an overriding goal to grow cricket among all South Africans, surely the best way of achieving that ambition was to do whatever we could to win the World Cup and to promote the game on the tidal wave of celebration that would then sweep through the entire country? Would anyone really mind if there were three or four players of colour in our side? Would anybody have decided to start playing or start following cricket just because there were four players of colour in the side, rather than three?

My mind was churning but, as the players gathered for the meeting, I had to keep everything together.

'Obviously, it's a huge game tomorrow,' I said, gesturing towards the 11 names on a white noticeboard. 'It will be a massive privilege for these okes to walk on the field tomorrow. Let's stick together no matter what happens out there. No matter what gets thrown in our direction, we're prepared to take it on.'

It was never my plan to say too much and I finished by referring to a specific line in one of my favourite songs; it is called 'I Lived' and was released by the US rock band OneRepublic in 2014.

I said: 'The line is "With every broken bone I swear I lived", and that sentiment goes hand in hand with some of the talks I have done before.